‘wheels that can go anywhere’, implying a monarch whose chariot can roll in any direction. The spokes of the wheel symbolize the various cardinal directions. Over the centuries, the symbolism of the wheel would be applied to both the temporal and the spiritual. We see the symbol used in imperial Mauryan symbols, Buddhist art and in the modern Indian nation’s flag.

Meanwhile, what happened to the defeated tribes? Some of the tribes would remain in Punjab, although much weakened. We know that the Druhya tribe was later chased away from Punjab to eastern Afghanistan. Their king Gandhara gave the region its ancient Indian name, which lingers on in the name of the Afghan city of Kandahar. The Puranas also tell us that the Druhyus would later migrate farther north to Central Asia and turn into Mlechhas (or foreign barbarians). [28] After that we hear nothing more of them. Another tribe called the Purus survived into the Mahabharata epic and probably accounts for King Porus who fought against the invading army of Alexander the Great in the fourth century BC.

Some of the tribes, however, appear to have fled further afield after the great battle. Two of them have names that suggest interesting possibilities: the Pakhta and the Parsu. The former are also mentioned by later Greek sources as Pactyians and one wonders if they are the ancestors of Pakhtun (or Pashtun) tribes that still live in Afghanistan and north-western Pakistan. This fits with the finding that, genetically speaking, the Pashtuns are related to Indians and not to Central Asians or Arabs as was previously thought.

Similarly, the Parsu are possibly related to the Persians because this is the name by which the Assyrians refer to the Persians in their inscriptions. This is not as fanciful a recreation of events as may appear at first glance. There is a great deal of evidence that links the Rig Vedic Indians to the ancient Persians. The Avesta, the oldest and most sacred text of the Zoroastrian religion, is written in a language that is almost identical to that of the Rig Veda. The older sections of the Avesta—called the Gathas—are said to have been composed by the prophet Zarathustra himself. They can be read as Rig Vedic Sanskrit by making a minor phonetic change. The Avestan ‘h’ is the same as the Sanskrit ‘s’. Thus, the word Sapta-Sindhu becomes Hapta-